

Factors Influencing Indian Students' Migration for Higher Education

An Analytical Survey | Department of Mathematics, Janki Devi Memorial College, University of Delhi

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Context: India's Student Migration Surge

1.8M

Indian Students Abroad

As of 2025, up from 1.3M just two years prior (MEA data)

331K

Students in USA

+23% year-over-year; India now #1 sender, surpassing China

137K

Students in Canada

–41% decline due to stricter visa and financial requirements

98K

Students in UK

–28% decline following dependent visa restrictions

India has one of the world's largest higher education systems (33,000+ colleges), yet a critical supply-demand gap in quality seats drives students abroad.

Research Problem & Objectives

The Research Gap

Despite extensive scholarship on student mobility, a critical gap persists in integrating **push-pull frameworks** with empirically validated decision-making models calibrated to Indian contexts. How do factors interact when mediated by parents, agents, and demographics?

Core Objectives

- Identify and classify institutional, push, pull, and personal factors
- Analyze relationships using regression and correlation techniques
- Understand mediating effects of third-party influences
- Explore demographic differences (gender, income, field of study)
- Construct an integrated conceptual model of Indian student migration

Push Factors: Why Students Leave India

Seat Scarcity

Only ~7,000 PG seats filled in IIT/NIT/IIIT (2021–22); 34% of engineering college seats remain vacant due to quality concerns

Quality Deficits

Many Indian institutions are unaccredited; curriculum, faculty, and research facilities lag international standards

Employment Crisis

India produces 1.5M engineering graduates yearly, yet job prospects at non-elite institutions remain dim; 76.3% cite higher pay as a key motivator

Brain Drain Aspirations

41% of Indian students are motivated by permanent residency goals; middle-class expansion enables this ambition

Pull Factors: Destination Country Appeal



United States

Top destination (331,602 students). OPT, H-1B pathways, scholarships, strong alumni networks



Canada

Declining (137,608, -41%). PR pathways and multiculturalism offset by tighter visa rules and diplomatic tensions



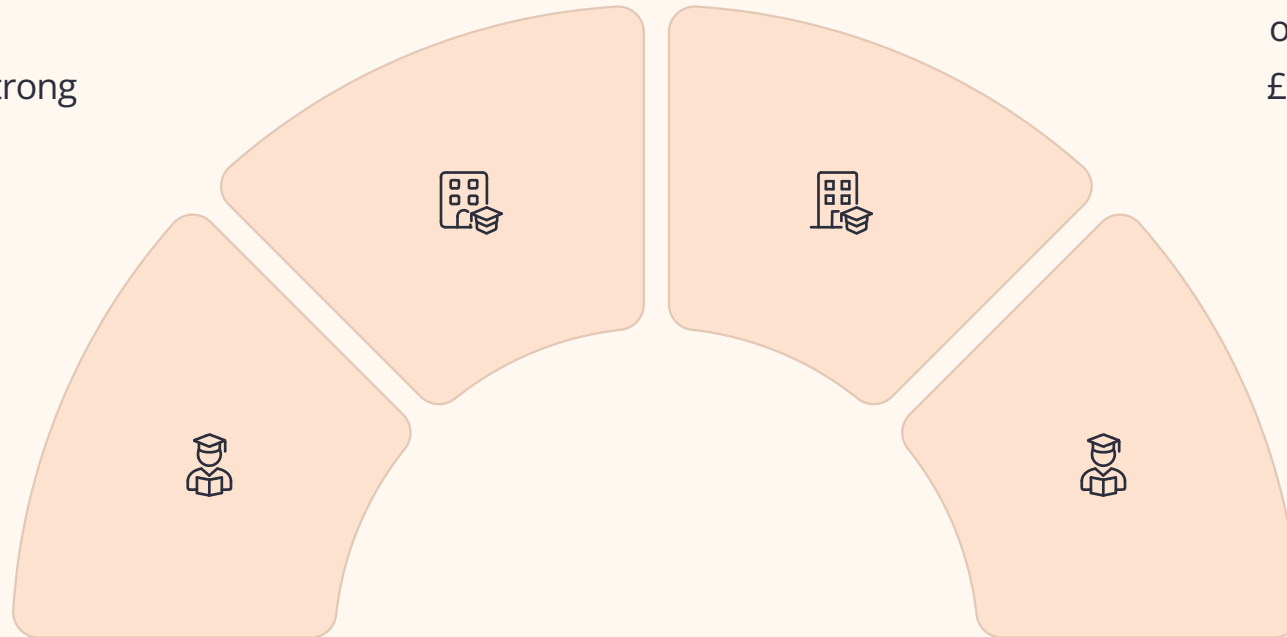
Germany

Fastest-growing (+138% in 5 years). Near-zero tuition, 18-month post-study work visa, engineering focus



United Kingdom

Declining (98,890, -28%). Elite reputation and 1-year Master's offset by high costs (£20K-£40K/year) and dependent restrictions



Financial, Social & Demographic Factors

Cost Structures (Annual)

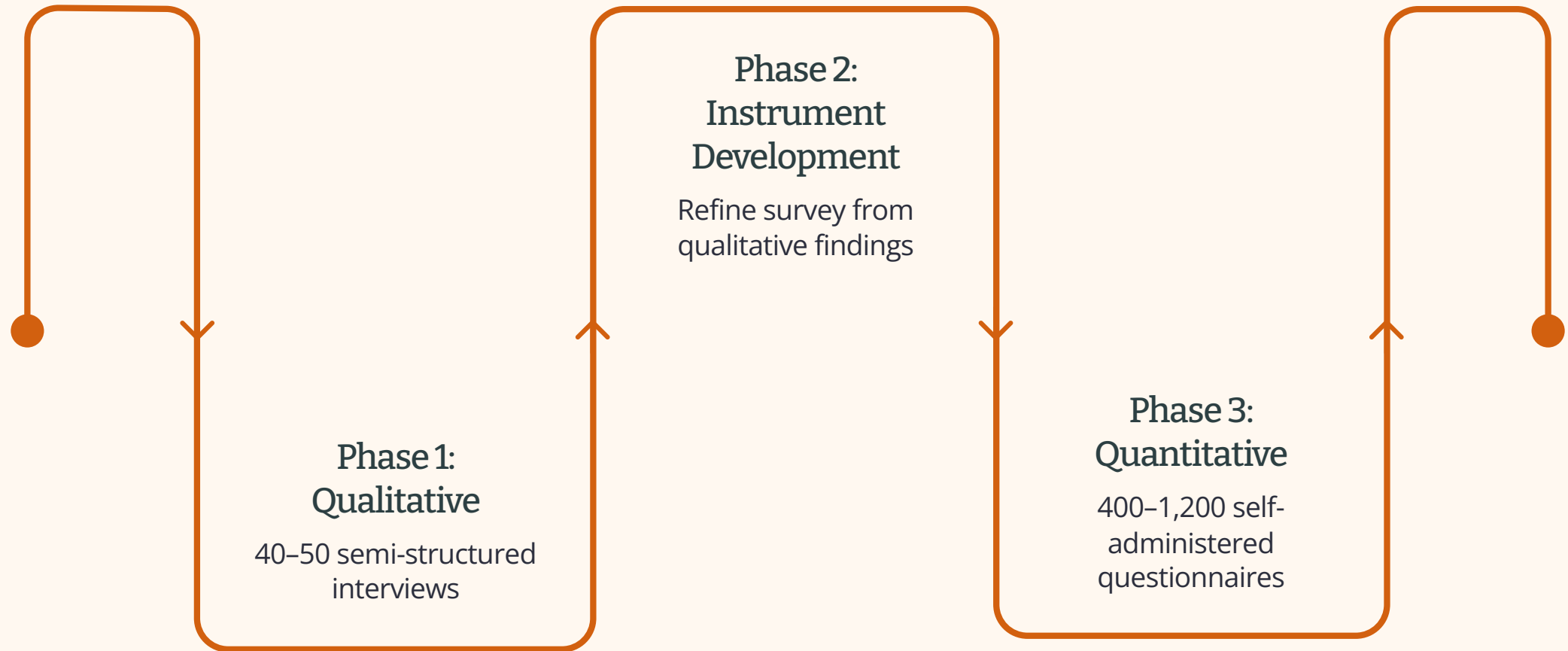
- **USA:** \$45,000–\$70,000
- **UK:** £25,000–£45,000
- **Canada:** \$20,000–\$30,000 CAD
- **Germany:** €0–€5,000
- **Australia:** \$30,000–\$45,000

65.7% consider scholarships a decisive factor. Education remittances exceeded **USD 5.17 billion** in FY2022 (+35% YoY).

Social & Demographic Dimensions

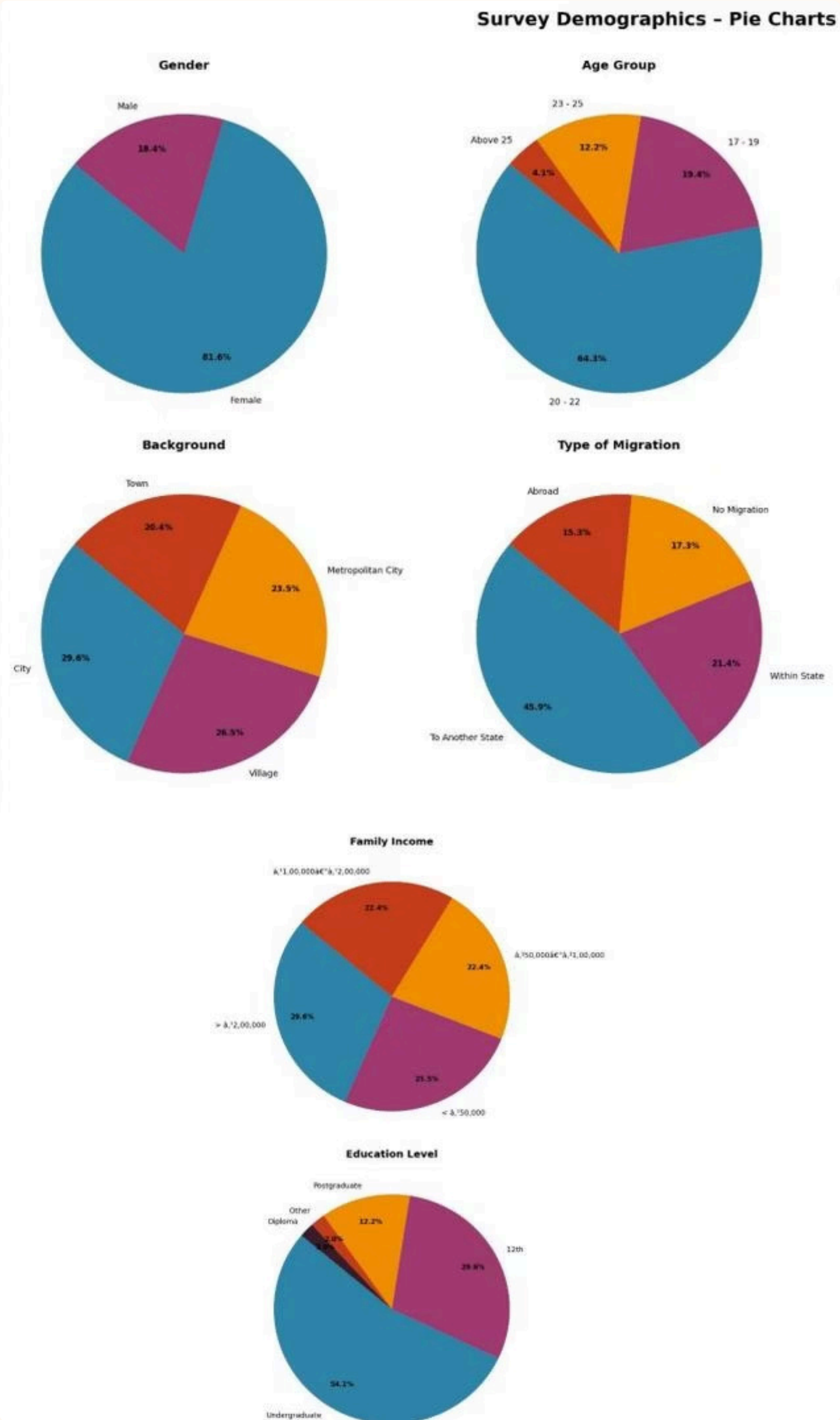
- **Family:** Major determinant; urban families increasingly support daughters studying abroad
- **Agents:** 78% of students consult agents for university, visa, and scholarship guidance
- **Gender:** Female enrollment rising; safety weighs heavily in destination choice
- **Income:** Families earning ₹10L+ prefer USA/UK; ₹2–5L prefer Germany/Eastern Europe
- **STEM:** 68–75% of Indian students choose STEM fields

Research Methodology



The study employs a **mixed-methods sequential exploratory design** across Ranchi, Jamshedpur, Dhanbad, and Bokaro. The 65-item questionnaire covers demographics, push factors, pull factors, third-party influences, information sources, and migration intention. Pilot-tested (n=50) with Cronbach's $\alpha > 0.80$ expected.

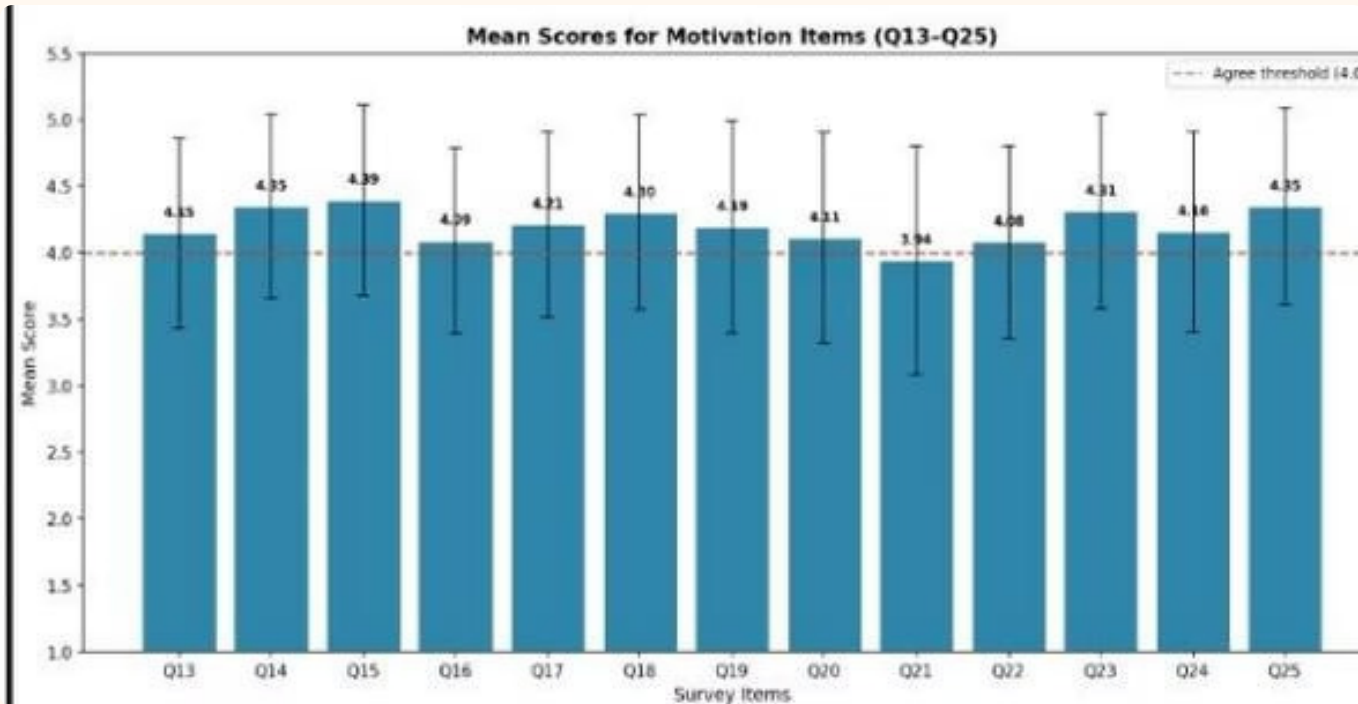
Survey Demographics (N = 98)



Key Respondent Profile

- **Gender:** 81.6% Female, 18.4% Male
- **Age:** 64.3% aged 20–22; 19.4% aged 17–19
- **Background:** 29.6% City, 26.5% Village, 20.4% Town
- **Education:** 54.1% Undergraduate, 29.4% 12th Grade
- **Migration Type:** 45.9% to another state, 15.3% abroad
- **Income:** 28.6% earn ₹3.5L–7L; 25.9% earn below ₹3.5L

Statistical Analysis Report



Key Findings (N = 89 valid)

- **All 13 items scored >4.0** (Agree threshold); Q15 (Independence) highest at 4.39, Q21 (Scholarships) lowest at 3.94
- **Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.8947$** — Excellent internal consistency
- **Kruskal-Wallis:** $H(3) = 2.07$, $p = 0.557$ — No significant difference across age groups
- **Mann-Whitney U:** $p = 0.9499$ — No gender difference in motivation
- **Regression $R^2 = 0.5729$** — Research facilities, career guidance, and long-term growth best predict family support
- **Odds Ratio = 0.90** — Motivation alone does not predict actual migration; financial and structural barriers moderate

Discussion & Conclusion

Career-Driven Decisions

Career growth, industry exposure, and practical experience are the dominant motivators — reflecting a shift from degree-attainment to competency-development.

Personal Development as Primary Driver

Independence, confidence, and communication skills rank highest. Students view migration as holistic self-development, not merely credential acquisition.

Family Role Evolving

Family support remains positive but no longer dominant. Students increasingly assert autonomy, balancing personal ambitions with social expectations.

Implications

Institutions must design skill-focused curricula; policymakers should enhance financial aid and quality access to reduce outflow aligned with SDG-4.